

vide a geographic (also geo-political) unity? Simply by drawing lines on maps? Through a 'surgical operation', Mountbatten had said, and tragically Nehru and Patel and the Congress party had assented, Jinnah, in any event having demanded adopting to just such a recourse.

The Muslim League in that sense triumphed under Jinnah's leadership, for he achieved what he had set out to. The League was his political instrument and his acumen enabled him to exploit the accumulated weaknesses of the Congress party's mistakes, principally from the 1930s onwards; upon which he heaped the British Empire's critical enfeeblement, post the Second World War, carving out for himself a Pakistan; even if 'moth-eaten' and from birth.



It is ironical that amongst the great constitutionalists of those times, and there were several, Jinnah and Nehru became the principal promoters of 'special status for Muslims'; Jinnah, directly, Nehru, indirectly. As all Indian citizens constitutionally were and are equal, then Jinnah by directly demanding a 'special' status for Muslims and Nehru through contesting Jinnah's right as their 'sole spokesman', became advocates of establishing different categories amongst Indian citizens. The irony of it is galling when sadly, (though, of course in retrospect) we observe that both of them, these two great Indians of their times were either actually or in effect competing to become the 'spokesman of Muslims' in India. This approach arose, principally, because they were, both in effect, so deeply imbued by European thought, percepts and societal subscriptions that they, tragically, became far removed from the core of Indian cultural consciousness. Then who, we wonder, remained to speak for a united India? Sadly, only Mahatma Gandhi.

The cruel truth is that this partitioning of India has actually resulted in achieving the very reverse of the originally intended purpose; partition, instead of settling contention between communities has left us a legacy of markedly enhanced Hindu, Muslim, Sikh or other such denominational identities, hence differences. Affirmative action, reservations for Muslims, other castes and communities unfortunately does not dissolve those identities; it heavily underscores them, waters their roots, perpetuating differences through the nutrient of self interest being poured constantly in separateness. Reservation results finally in compartmentalising society, hence ultimately in frag-



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menting national identity. That is what 'special reservation' for Muslims in India did.



Jinnah saw Congress as his adversary and his nemesis. It was Congress versus the Muslim League, two parties contending for power in an independent Indian state that led to partition. Gandhi unlike Nehru did not share the view that Congress should take power in an independent Indian state. For him, Congress was a vehicle for the independence movement and for a constructive work movement. He rarely took interest in Congress party affairs. In his last will and testament written the day before he was assassinated on 30 January 1948, he called on the Congress